

cattle futures than he ever made off Shakespeare, and in fact had changed careers to better provide for his family. For her part, she'd begun to trade hog futures to make tuition at Yale Medical School.

Yale Medical School is not cheap—and that fact, coupled with the fact that Ms. Quattrocki had taken the opposite side of my own long position in hog calls—led me to ask her point-blank if I'd done the wrong thing. "I hope so," she said. "Since if you win, I lose. This is a zero-sum game, you know." Mr. Epstein had said the same, but it hadn't really sunk in until I heard it on the rim of the hog pit, and from the mouth of a rival.

I caved in then and there and offered to sell Ms. Quattrocki the two hog calls I'd bought from her at cost so at least we'd both break even. She politely refused. She'd heard that Merrill Lynch was coming in and "crushing the market with paper," which she predicted would depress the hog prices, so she was happy to sit with her short positions and let me get stuck on the long side.

After a second day on the floor, I still hadn't met any high-rollers. The most successful person I'd encountered was Ms. Quattrocki, and even she had to worry about tuition. Whenever a trader told me a story about some other trader who'd made an absolute fortune, the lucky person had always quit the exchange, disappeared from town, left no forwarding address, or else the storyteller couldn't remember the name.

Mr. Epstein introduced me to Jeff Zaret, a 25-year-old who had chosen the stock-index-futures pit over college. I visited Mr. Zaret at his office on an upper floor, where I think I woke him up from a nap on the couch. He had a good-natured twinkle in his eye, a hint of a pot belly, and a two-day growth of beard. When I asked if he knew any millionaires, Mr. Zaret said he once stood next to a guy in the stock-index pit who'd made \$650,000 in three hours. Just like the others, Mr. Zaret couldn't recall the guy's name. Soon, he was telling me the story of his own struggle to survive in the business, where it was "getting harder and harder to make a profit."

"There's so much competition at the margins, so many people chasing the last little dollar," he said, "that it's getting thinner and thinner for locals like me. I still rent my seat on the exchange from